

credit. So did every couple that ever got into debt. Rarely does anyone set out to get into debt. Virtually every couple I ever counseled who was in debt said the same thing. "How in the world did we get into a mess like this?"

Drew and Nan were seemingly the ideal couple. They both graduated from college on the dean's list. Drew went on to law school while Nan took a teaching position.

After law school, Drew joined a law firm headed by Nan's father. Everyone assumed their large home was provided by their well-to-do parents. But in reality it was provided by extending themselves far beyond their income. As creditors began to press them, Drew began to speculate in stocks, trying desperately to hit the "big one" and get out of debt. He knew that any open publicity about their financial troubles would severely injure his career.

Nan was totally ignorant of their finances and took Drew's word that their lifestyle was supported by bonuses from the law firm. In actuality, Drew was systematically taking money from clients' trust accounts which he was managing. The final blow came with a bank-directed audit of the trust accounts. When the audit was completed, it revealed a \$64,000 deficit in client trust funds. Drew was disbarred from practicing law and served three years in a federal prison—all because of a desire by him and his wife to live beyond their means.

Drew didn't consider himself dishonest. He always intended to repay the accounts and kept detailed records of what he "borrowed." Many other couples have faced similar situations, only they have borrowed from friends, family, and creditors. Their defaults were considered legal because they filed bankruptcy. Yet the emotional and spiritual consequences were very similar.

Lenders promote the idea that you should establish credit early. Obviously so; that's how they earn their living. But the longer you can go without credit (and credit cards), the less you will depend on it later. Whatever you do, don't use credit for consumable items such as clothes, food, vacations, or repairs. We're the only generation in history to borrow signifi-